Bruner's Narrative Theory for Defiance Course

Contents

Jerome Bruner's 1991 essay, **"The Narrative Construction of Reality,"** is a seminal text in cognitive psychology and literary theory. In it, he argues that narrative is not just a literary form, but a "mode of thought" that humans use to organize their experience and construct the reality they live in.

Below is a summary of his main points followed by their application to our course.

Summary of Main Points: The 10 Features of Narrative

Bruner identifies ten specific characteristics that allow narrative to function as a way of constructing reality:

- **Narrative Diachronicity:** Narratives take place over time. They are not just a series of events but a sequence that carries a specific temporal logic (beginning, middle, and end).
- **Particularity:** Stories are about specific people and specific events. While they may have universal themes, they start with the particular rather than the general or the abstract.
- **Intentional State Entailment:** Characters in a story have "intentional states"—beliefs, desires, theories, and values. The story is driven by what the characters are thinking and feeling, rather than just physical laws.
- **Hermeneutic Composability:** The "whole" of the story is understood through its "parts," and the parts are understood in relation to the whole. To understand a story, the reader must interpret the relationship between events and the overall meaning.
- **Canonicity and Breach:** This is perhaps Bruner's most famous point. For a story to be worth telling, it must "breach" a "canonical" script. It must describe a violation of what is normally expected in a culture.
- **Referentiality:** Narrative "truth" is not the same as scientific truth. A story doesn't have to be factually "true" to be "real." It only needs "verisimilitude"—the appearance of being true to life.
- **Genericness:** We understand stories through genres (tragedy, comedy, etc.). These genres provide a "mental template" that helps us categorize and interpret our lives.
- **Normativeness:** Narratives are inherently moral. By showing a "breach" of the norm, they reinforce what the norm is or should be. They deal with "the way things ought to be."
- **Context Sensitivity and Negotiability:** Narrative meaning is not fixed; it is negotiated between the teller and the listener. The context in which a story is told changes its meaning.
- **Narrative Accrual:** Cultures do not just have one story; they accrue a "web" of stories. These stories build upon each other to create a tradition or a shared cultural history.

Application to "Tales of Defiance to a Mentally Controlled World"

Bruner's framework can help analyzing how story-telling becomes an act of rebellion, with a focus on how individuals resist systems of indoctrination, propaganda, or psychological manipulation. Below we suggest how some of Bruner's theme's can be turned into questions that can be asked about each story.

1. ***Intentional State Entailment*** **: Reclaiming Interiority**
   - **Question:** Mental control often attempts to flatten a person's inner life. How does the narrative use the "intentional states" (private thoughts) of the characters to defy the external world?
   - **Comment:** The narrative focuses on the character's secret desires and doubts. Because the reader has access to the character's mind, the reader sees a "hidden reality" that the controlling system cannot see, thereby validating the character's humanity against the machine.

2. ***Canonicity and Breach*** **: The Breach as Defiance**
   - **Question:** In a "mentally controlled world," the system provides the "canonical script" (how one should think and act). How does the protagonist of our story create a "breach" in that script?
   - **Comment:** Defiance begins when a character performs an action that the system cannot account for. By breaking the expected "script" of the controlled society, the character proves that the system's reality is not the only reality.

3. ***Referentiality*** **: Narrative Truth vs. Systemic "Truth"**
   - **Question:** In propaganda-heavy worlds, "truth" is whatever the state says. How does a "tale of defiance" use *narrative truth* to expose the lies of *systemic truth*?
   - **Comment:** A story doesn't need to present a spreadsheet of facts to defeat a controlling system; it only needs to feel "truer" to human experience. When a character's story resonates with the reader's sense of reality, the abstract "truth" of the mental controllers begins to crumble.

4. ***Genericness*** **: The Power of Genre**
   - **Question:** Why do we often use the "Dystopian" genre to talk about mental control? How does the genre itself help us understand what "defiance" looks like?
   - **Comment:** Genres are mental maps. The "Dystopian" genre prepares the reader to look for the "outsider" or the "rebel." By framing a life-story as a "tale of defiance," the narrator uses a known genre to give the audience a roadmap for how they might resist in their own lives.

5. ***Narrative Accrual*** **: Building a Counter-Culture**
   - **Question:** How do individual acts of defiance "accrue" into a movement?
   - **Comment:** Defiance is rarely a single act. It is a collection of stories passed from person to person. As these stories build up (accrual), they create a "counter-history" that competes with the official history of the controlling world, eventually providing a new foundation for a free society.